

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 269

Culture (OWC): [Ovambo \(FX08\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1947-1948

Coverage Date: 1800 AD - 1948 AD

Place Coverage

north-central Namibia; Cunene Province, Angola

Section Title(S)

Land and Dwellings . • Southern Neighbors of the Kuanyama • The Ombandja • The Ondonga .

The Ombandja

The Ombandja have never been studied. Their last king, Mongola, died in 1914. During his reign he ruled over one section of the country and made his brother, Setekela, ruler over another. At present Ombandja is a part of Kuanyama Land, and Johannes (native name Hitombua) represents the Ombandja among the Kuanyama Headmen.

101
Identification

629
Multi-Ethnic
Community Relations

643
Chief Executive

The Ombandja use the kudu horn ([enghuma](#)), with a skin covering one end, at the [efundula](#). The girls are told that it is an [edila](#) (bird, or bullroarer) such as is used at the boys' circumcision, and they are not allowed to see it. The Ombandja girls do not go about as ash girls after their [efundula](#).

237
Animal By-Products

562
Gender Status

778
Sacred Objects And
Places

881
Puberty And Initiation

The kinship system of the Ombandja is practically the same as that of the Kuanyama. However, cross-cousin marriage is still the custom. The reciprocal term ometzi jangi (my bull) is used for cross-cousins of opposite sexes. Cross-cousins married to one another do not have to avoid their parents-in-law. Our informant, Headman Johannes, maintained that cross-cousin marriages are more stable than other marriages and that the wives do not run away so often. In this tribe a man may joke with any girl of his own age in his father's clan and call her "my bull." In general, among most of the Ambo about whom we have information, there is a tendency for men to flirt with women of the father's clan, as is a frequent practice with matrilineal peoples.

582
Regulation Of Marriage

600
Kinship

602
Kin Relationships

606
Parents-In-Law And
Children-In-Law

614
Clans

Southern Neighbors of the Kuanyama

The Ondonga.

Previous authors have given a fairly comprehensive account of the Ondonga.¹⁷ To facilitate a comparison of this tribe with other neighboring tribes, a few new observations will be presented here in addition to a summary of some of the principal features mentioned in the earlier descriptions.

114
Reviews And Critiques

128
Organization And
Analysis Of Results

Land and Dwellings.

As has been said already,¹⁸ Ovamboland becomes increasingly arid as one goes from the north and east to the south and west. The Ondonga, who live to the south of Kuanyama Land, are predominately an agricultural people; their country has too little water and grass to support many large herds of cattle.¹⁹

The lack of wood is so great that except for the  270 king's kraal, the queen mother's ombala, and the kraals of the headmen, the dwellings are made of dry grain stalks, and straw mixed with dried cow dung is used for firewood. "The stalks that the cattle leave uneaten in the fields are gathered and used for roofing material, or are mixed with dried cattle dung and used in the fireplaces."²⁰

101
Identification

113
Bibliographies In
Sources

128
Organization And
Analysis Of Results

132
Climate

137
Flora

161
Population

175
History

237
Animal By-Products

318

Human Effects On
Environment

342
Dwellings

372
Fire

17. C. Hahn is the principal authority on the Ondonga.

18. See Chapter 1, pp. 3, 6.

19. Schinz maintains that before the time of King Nembungu the Ondonga lived farther east and south than they do today. He says that the present site must have belonged to the Ongandjera dynasty, which owned the land. Although today the Ongandjera are an insignificant tribe with only 8,854 inhabitants, formerly, according to Schinz, they were a large and powerful tribe. An indication of their importance is the fact that the Bushmen came from far and wide to trade with them. (Schinz, 1891, pp. 321–322.)

20. *Ibid.*, p. 297.

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries: ✉ hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs: ✉ hraf-support@yale.edu



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)